INTERNAL AUDIT REPORT

QUALITATIVE INTERVIEW – CONSENT, STAKEHOLDER SELECTION AND DOCUMENTATION

Project: MATHRU – ICMR-Funded Study
Audit Area: Qualitative Interview – Consent, Stakeholder Selection and Documentation
Date of Audit: 15-Sep-2026
Date of Report: 17-Sep-2026
Reviewed By: VEMULA HARSHAVARDHAN

Total Observations/Queries: 10
Queries Resolved: 10
Queries Pending: 0
Overall Status: CLOSED

1. PURPOSE OF THE AUDIT

An internal audit of the qualitative interview documentation and study records was conducted to assess the **completeness, accuracy, consistency, ethical appropriateness, and adequacy of documentation** associated with stakeholder interviews conducted under the MATHRU project.

The review included consent documentation, participant details, recording authorisation, witness-related entries, stakeholder selection, and potential conflict-of-interest or role-related bias considerations.

2. AUDIT OBSERVATIONS AND RESOLUTION

No.	Reference / Area	Observation	Resolution / Corrective Action	CAPA / Preventive Action	Status
1	Asha	Signature was required in both the Witness and Subject sections of the consent form.	The original consent record was reviewed. The participant was a competent, literate adult and an impartial witness was therefore not required. No correction to the original consent form was made.	Study team briefed that the witness field should be completed only when an impartial witness is required and otherwise left blank or marked N/A as permitted.	**Closed**

2	Yogish	Date of PE Consent was missing from the consent documentation.	The original consent form and contemporaneous records were reviewed. The consent date was verified using the participant logbook and interview-related records. Corrective action was completed in the presence of the audit team.	A same-day consent-completeness check will be performed before each interview, followed by a second review before filing.	**Closed**
3	Dr. Jibu Thomas	Recording/Record checkbox had not been ticked.	The consent and interview records were reviewed. The applicable checkbox was completed based on the available documentation and participant consent.	Recording permission and all applicable consent fields will be verified before initiating recording and reviewed again before filing.	**Closed**
4	Nagaraj A.S.	Both recording checkboxes had not been ticked.	The consent and interview records were reviewed. The applicable recording checkboxes were completed based on the available documentation and participant consent.	Recording authorisation and applicable fields will be checked before recording and during the pre-filing review.	**Closed**
5	Dr. Shiran Shetty	Study team personnel had signed in the Witness Signature section dated 24-Feb-2026.	The original consent record was reviewed. The participant was a competent, literate adult and an impartial witness was not required. No alteration or erasure was made to the original record. The unnecessary witness entry was documented in the audit response.	Study personnel were instructed not to sign the impartial-witness field unless an eligible impartial witness is required.	**Closed**
6	Dr. Margi	Study team personnel had signed in the Witness Signature section dated 07-Apr-2026.	The original consent record was reviewed. The participant was a competent, literate adult and an impartial witness was not required. No alteration or erasure was made to the original record.	Study personnel were instructed regarding appropriate use of the witness field and documentation requirements.	**Closed**
7	Dr. Sheetal Raj	Handwritten names/details were noted, while the participant's name and associated details were printed	It was confirmed that the participant was an external stakeholder interviewed online. Participant details were pre-filled by the study team and sent electronically for participant	For online interviews, participant details will be pre-filled and verified against the participant logbook and returned signed consent	**Closed**

		on the consent documentation, requiring verification.	review and signature. The returned signed copy and related correspondence confirmed identity and consent. No correction was required.	documentation.	
8	Gayatri	Name/details on the Public Representative Form required verification, including the recorded consent date.	Source documentation was reviewed. The participant was an external stakeholder interviewed online. The returned signed consent form and related correspondence confirmed participant identity and consent date. No correction was required.	Online participant details will be verified against the participant logbook and returned signed consent documentation before filing.	**Closed**
9	Thomas M.J.	Study team personnel had signed in the Witness Signature section.	The original consent record was reviewed. The participant was a competent, literate adult and an impartial witness was not required. No alteration or erasure was made to the original consent form. The unnecessary witness entry was documented in the audit response.	Study personnel were instructed not to sign the impartial-witness field unless an eligible impartial witness is required.	**Closed**
10	Stakeholder Selection / Potential COI and Bias	Some individuals serving as Co-Principal Investigators were also included as stakeholder interview participants. This dual role presented a potential non-financial conflict of interest and possible risk of role-related or social-desirability bias.	The dual role was acknowledged and assessed. Stakeholders were purposively selected based on their relevant expertise, direct experience, and responsibility for implementation of the proposed changes. In stakeholder categories where individuals with the required knowledge and experience were limited, exclusion solely on the basis of Co-PI status could have resulted in omission of important clinical, administrative, and implementation perspectives. In accordance with the applicable ICMR ethical framework, the potential conflict was managed rather than treated as an automatic exclusion criterion. Participation remained voluntary	Future qualitative stakeholder selection will document the rationale for inclusion where a participant has a dual investigator/stakeholder role. Potential conflicts and sources of bias will be identified prospectively and appropriate mitigation measures will be documented. Independent analysis will be maintained wherever feasible.	**Closed**

			and was based on informed consent. Qualitative data were analysed independently by researchers who had no direct professional relationship with the stakeholder participants, thereby reducing the potential influence of Co-PI status on interpretation of findings.		

3. SPECIFIC AUDIT CLARIFICATION – STAKEHOLDER DUAL ROLE

During the review of the qualitative stakeholder interview process, it was identified that some individuals who served as **Co-Principal Investigators (Co-PIs)** were also included as stakeholder interview participants.

Their dual role represented a potential **non-financial conflict of interest** and a potential source of **role-related or social-desirability bias**. This was therefore considered as part of the audit review.

However, the stakeholder selection process was based on **purposive selection**, with participants identified according to their relevant expertise, direct experience, and responsibility for implementing the proposed changes.

In certain stakeholder categories, the number of individuals with the required clinical, administrative, or implementation knowledge and experience was limited. Excluding individuals solely because of their Co-PI status could therefore have resulted in the loss of important perspectives relevant to the research question.

The dual role was consequently **acknowledged and managed rather than treated as an automatic ground for exclusion**. Participation was voluntary and based on informed consent.

To mitigate the potential influence of the participant's investigator role on the qualitative findings, the data were analysed independently by researchers who had **no direct professional relationship with the stakeholder participants**. This provided an additional measure to reduce potential influence arising from the participants' Co-PI status during interpretation of the qualitative data.

The audit review therefore confirmed that the potential conflict and associated risk of bias had been **identified, considered, and addressed through documented methodological safeguards**.

4. SUMMARY OF AUDIT FINDINGS

A total of **10 observations/queries** were identified during the qualitative audit review.

The observations related to:

- Completeness of consent documentation.
- Consent dates.
- Recording authorisation.
- Witness documentation.
- Participant identity and details.
- Online stakeholder consent documentation.
- Stakeholder selection.
- Potential non-financial conflict of interest.
- Potential role-related/social-desirability bias.
- Measures adopted to mitigate potential influence during qualitative data analysis.

Query Closure Summary

Audit Parameter	**Status**
Total queries/observations identified	10
Queries addressed	10
Queries closed	10
Pending queries	0
Closure rate	**100%**
Overall audit status	**Closed**

5. CORRECTIVE AND PREVENTIVE ACTION (CAPA)

Based on the audit findings, the following corrective and preventive measures were documented:

1. Consent forms will undergo a completeness check before filing.
2. Consent dates will be verified against the relevant source documentation.
3. Recording authorisation will be confirmed before recording begins.
4. The impartial witness field will be used only when an eligible impartial witness is required.
5. Online stakeholder details will be verified against participant records and returned signed consent documentation.
6. Stakeholder selection rationale will be documented where participants have a dual investigator/stakeholder role.
7. Potential conflicts of interest and sources of role-related or social-desirability bias will be identified and documented.
8. Appropriate mitigation measures will be applied where a potential conflict or bias is identified.
9. Independent qualitative analysis will be maintained wherever feasible to reduce potential influence arising from investigator or professional relationships.
10. The study team will maintain appropriate documentation to demonstrate the rationale for participant selection and the measures used to manage potential bias.

6. ETHICAL AND METHODOLOGICAL CONSIDERATIONS

The audit confirmed that the potential dual role of certain Co-PIs as stakeholder participants was considered as an ethical and methodological issue rather than being overlooked.

The approach adopted was based on:

- Voluntary participation.
- Informed consent.
- Purposive stakeholder selection based on relevant expertise and experience.
- Recognition of the potential for non-financial conflict of interest.
- Recognition of possible role-related or social-desirability bias.

- Documentation of the rationale for inclusion.
- Independent analysis of qualitative data by researchers without direct professional relationships with the stakeholder participants.

These measures were documented as safeguards to support the credibility and integrity of the qualitative research process.

7. AUDIT QUERY CLOSURE

All **10 observations/queries** identified during the qualitative audit review have been reviewed and addressed.

The corresponding responses, corrective actions, preventive measures, and supporting documentation have been recorded in the **Audit Query Log – Qualitative Interview Documentation**.

There are **no outstanding queries from this audit cycle**.

Final Closure Status: CLOSED

8. CONCLUSION

The qualitative audit of the MATHRU project was completed with review of consent documentation, stakeholder interview records, participant details, and relevant methodological considerations.

A total of **10 observations/queries** were identified. Following review and verification, all observations were addressed and the required corrective and preventive measures were documented.

The potential dual role of certain Co-PIs as stakeholder interview participants was specifically considered. The potential non-financial conflict of interest and risk of role-related/social-desirability bias were acknowledged and managed through purposive selection, voluntary informed participation, documentation of the selection rationale, and independent analysis by researchers without direct professional relationships with the stakeholder participants.

All **10 queries have been resolved and closed**, with no outstanding observations from this audit cycle.

9. SIGNATURES

Reviewed/Approved by:

Name: VEMULA HARSHAVARDHAN

Designation: Ethics & Regulatory Documentation Officer

MATHRU Project



Signature:

Date: 28-Sep-2026